Wealth Confiscation and Elite Persistence: Evidence from the Great Reduction

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Motivation

Societies experience upheavals where established elites are stripped of their wealth:

- The French Revolution, the dissolution of the monasteries, the oprichnina, etc

Whether such losses persist determines how deeply upheavals reshape the elite.

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Research Question

How are elite families affected and how do they adapt in the long run when faced with wealth shocks?

This Paper

Question

- How are elite families affected and how do they adapt to wealth shocks?

Setting

- The Great Reduction of 1680, Sweden's largest wealth shock

Data

- New genealogical data on universe of noble families spanning three centuries

Results

- Effects of wealth shock persist across generations
  - Estimates in lines with intergenerational correlations in wealth
  - Regression to the mean implies limited effects over the very long-run

Outline

Historical context

Nobility of Sweden

Historical manors in Sweden and Finland

Directly affected individuals

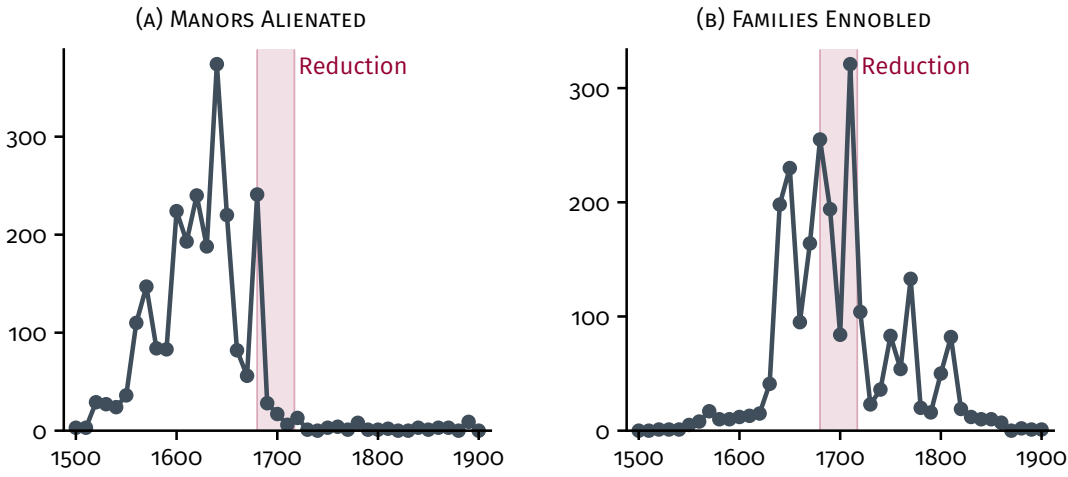
Descendants of affected individuals

Conclusion

Background: Policy of Enfeoffment, 1580–1680

- In the 1600s, Sweden funded its military campaigns by granting fiefs to the nobility
- The nobility gradually gained economic and political power from 1580 to 1680

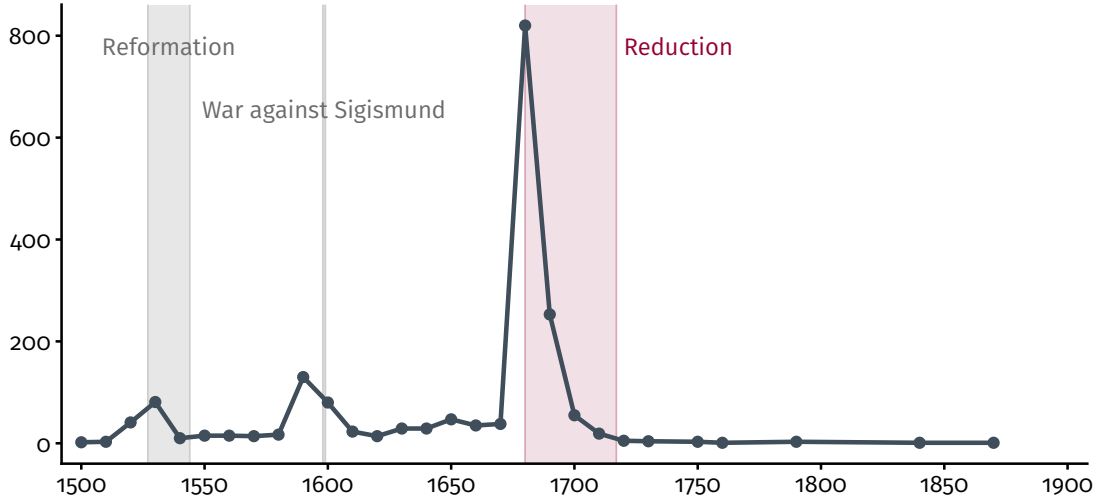
Manors alienated and families ennobled, 1500–1900



Great Reduction

- In 1680, backed by peasants, clergy, and burghers, Charles XI launched the **Great Reduction**
  - The Crown confiscated half of noble land
  - The Privy Council was dissolved and the Riksdag subordinated

Manors Confiscated



Source: Ulväng (2026)

Distribution of Land in Sweden, 1520–1885

	Cadastral category			
Year	Noble	Ecclesiastical	Crown	Freehold
1520	25	25	6	45
1560	23		30	47
1654	65			
1700	33		35	32
1750	33			
1825	33		13	54
1878	32		8	60
1885	33		8	59

Estimates based on Myrdal (1996), Nilsson (1958), Gadd (2020), and Lindgren (2021).

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  - Example: De la Gardie
- **Historical Manors in Sweden and Finland** (Ulväng, 2026)
  - Ownership records (type, location, owner, etc.) on 15.7K manors
  - Example: Läckö Castle

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- **Historical Manors in Sweden and Finland** (Ulväng, 2026)
  - Ownership records (type, location, owner, etc.) on 15.7K manors
  - Example: Läckö Castle
- **Manors of the Nobility of Sweden** (authors' dataset)
  - String matching, with an LLM resolving ties (validated on a large manually matched sample)

Nobility of Sweden

Based on House of Nobility's **Minerva** released earlier this year.

- **Full count** of Swedish nobility from the 15th to the early 20th century
  - **139,000 individuals** in 2,885 families, including 30,000 title-bearing fathers
- **Biographies** with census-like information
  - LLMs extract occupation, demographic information, partners, and more
- **Exact genealogical links** connect parents and children across generations

Extracting Key Variables Using LLMs

TAB 2

Johan De la Gardie (son av Pontus, friherre De la Gardie, Tab. 1), friherre till Ekholmen, herre till Kjulaholm och Rasik samt Kåreholm i Röne kapellförsaml. Östergötlands län. Född 1582-05-03 i Reval. Erhöll stadfästelse på friherrskapet Ekholmen av konung Sigismund 1594-01-01 (1/6). Ståthållare på Åbo slott och över dess län 1611-09-15. Förordnad att rannsaka och avdöma klagomål mot ståthållare, lagläsare och länsmän i Finland 1614-06-07. Erhöll donation på gods i Satakunda s. å. Ståthållare över Tavastehus län 1616-05-16. Introd. 1625 bland friherrar under nr 4. Guvernör på Reval och över Estland 1626-03-06. Lantmarskalk vid 1630 års riksdag. Landshövding över Uppland 1631. Generalståthållare på Stockholms och Uppsala slott med dess underlydande län 1632. Riksråd 1633-02-04. Hovrättsråd i Svea hovrätt 1634-12-18. Död 1640-03-10 på Steninge i Husby socken, Uppsala län utan söner och slöt således på svärdssidan frih. ätten De la Gardie, samt begraven s. å. 12/7 i Veckholms kyrka. […] Gift 1:o 16(09) med friherrinnan **Catharina Oxenstierna**, begraven 1625-03-06 i Björkviks kyrka Södermanlands län […]. Gift 2:o 1635-12-13 i Stockholm med **Görvel Posse** […].



Occupation	Year
Ståthållare på Åbo slott	1611-09-15
Förordnad att rannsaka och avdöma klagomål	1614-06-07
Ståthållare över Tavastehus län	1616-05-16
Guvernör på Reval och över Estland	1626-03-06
Lantmarskalk vid 1630 års riksdag	1630
Landshövding över Uppland	1631
Generalståthållare på Stockholms och Uppsala slott	1632
Riksråd	1633-02-04
Hovrättsråd i Svea hovrätt	1634-12-18

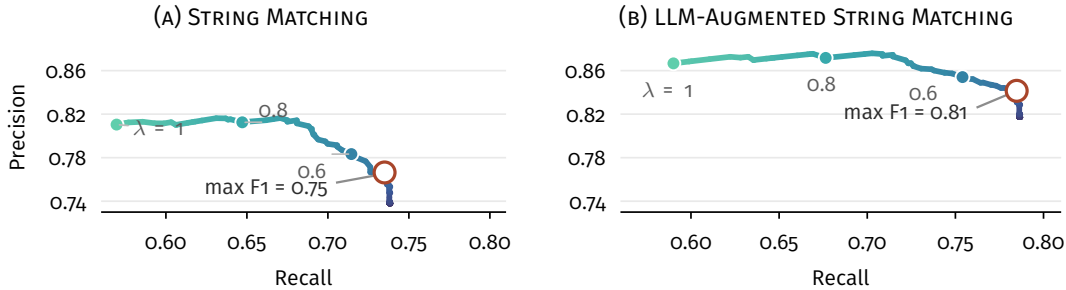
Latitude	Longitude	Place name
59.6511	17.5972	Steninge, Husby socken, Uppsala län

First name	Family name	Year
Catharina	Oxenstierna	1609
Görvel	Posse	1635

Historical Manors in Sweden and Finland

- The most comprehensive database of Swedish and Finnish historical manors:
  - 15.7K manors and 130K property events, recording owners, locations, and tenure
  - Includes all:
    - Manors named by Elgenstierna (1925–1936)
    - Manors in Almquist (1931–1976), covering 41% of Swedish taxable land in 1700
- Supplement with **Heraldica** National Archives of Finland
  - 3% of manors in regression sample.

Linking manors to noble individuals



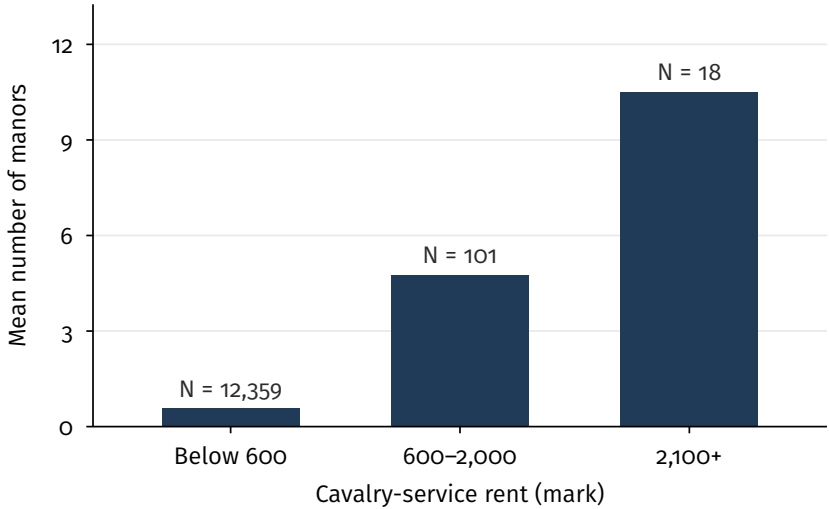
- Generate candidate matches from names and ownership periods
- Use an LLM to resolve candidates from passages and ownership sequences

⇒ F1 rises from 0.75 to 0.81 in manually linked sample of all **confiscated** manors

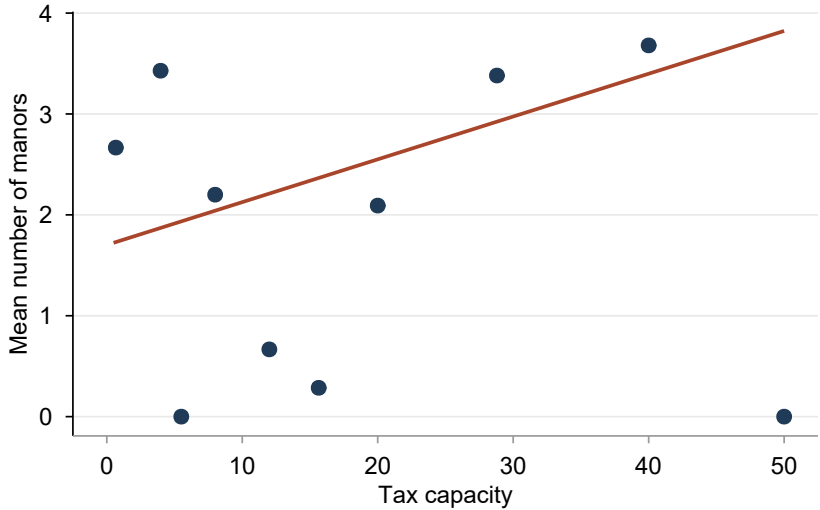
  - Precision: share of proposed links that are correct
  - Recall: share of correct links that are found

F1: harmonic mean of precision and recall

More manors, **higher cavalry-service rent** (nobles in 1655 & 1697)



More manors, **higher tax capacity** (nobles alive 1550–1650)



N=270 nobles with recorded lifespans overlapping 1550–1650. Tax capacity: 1613 Älvsborg ransom levy categories

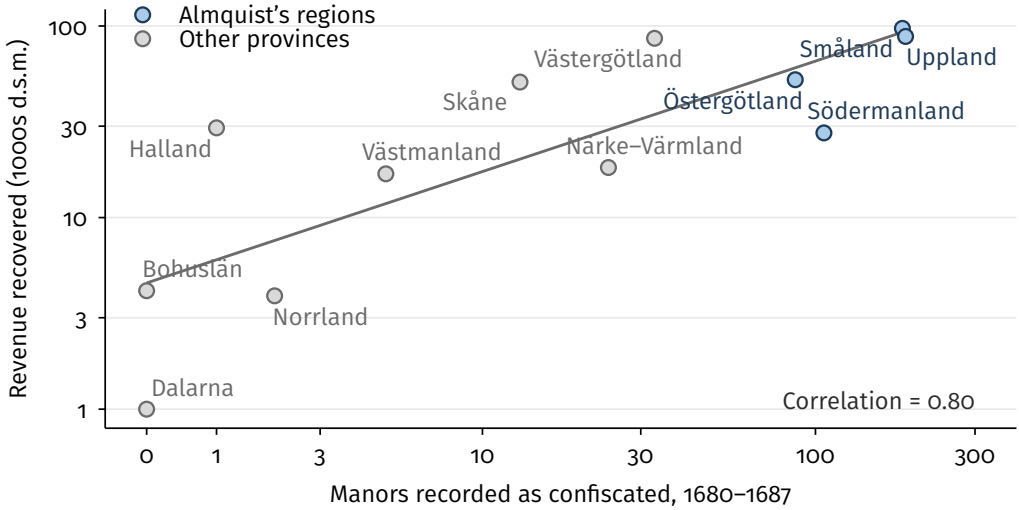
Identifying affected nobles

1. Find a manor confiscated by the Crown between 1680 and 1717
2. Identify its last *observed* owner before confiscation

This gives us:

- **355** affected nobles in the first-stage sample, of which **307** have observed descendants
- **Example:** Magnus Gabriel De la Gardie lost 12 manors, the most in the sample

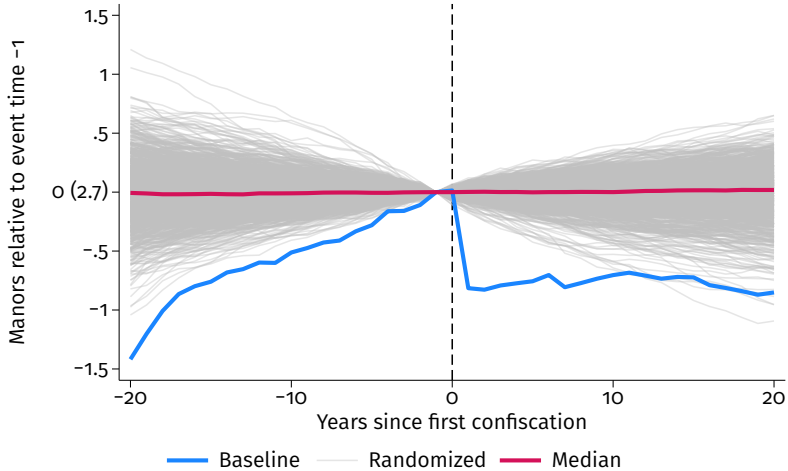
More manors confiscated, **more annual revenue recovered**



Provinces of present-day Sweden, revenue recovered by the Crown (Svedelius, 1849–1851). Log scales

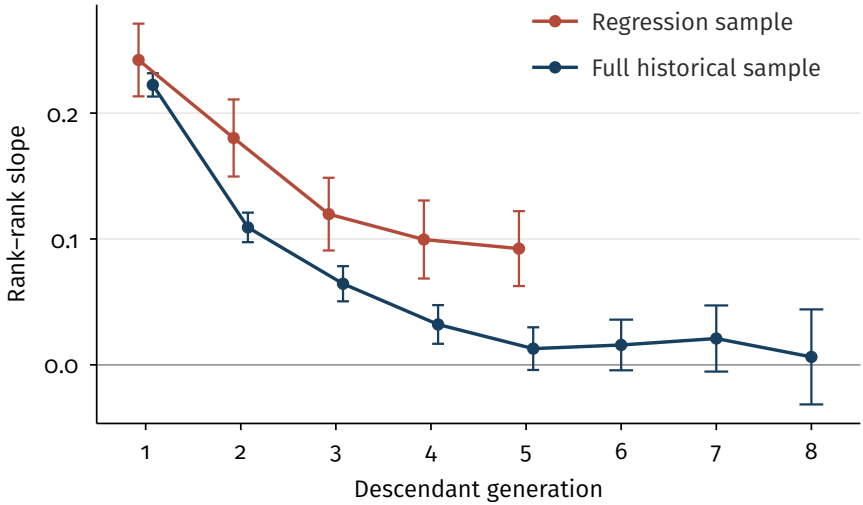
Results

Confiscation cut manor holdings by **30%**, with no recovery



Holdings averaged 2.7 manors the year before confiscation. Gray lines: 1,000 placebo assignments

The relationship between ancestral and descendant wealth fades slowly



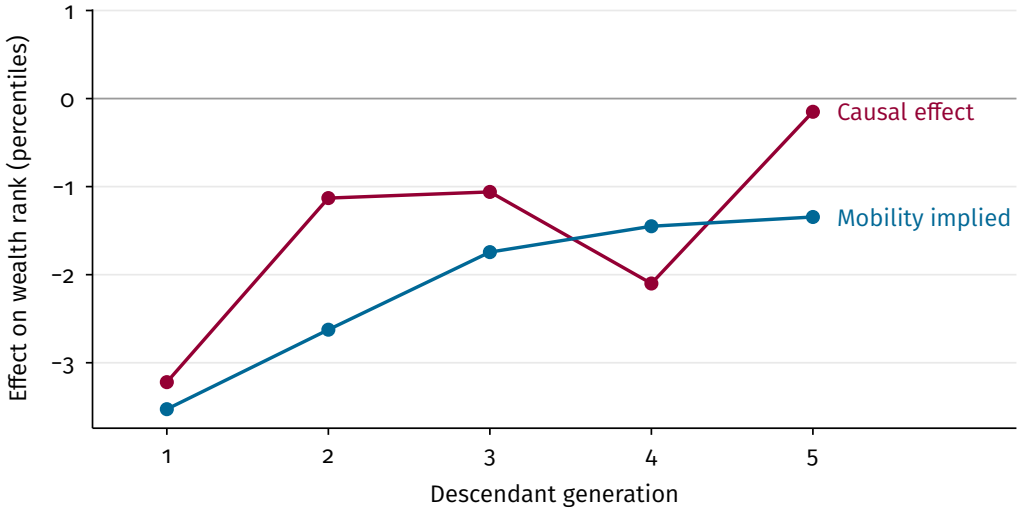
Wealth ranked within generation. Bars show 95% confidence intervals

Effects on descendant wealth

				Affected		
Generation	Observations	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
1 (Children)	3,522	−1.88 (1.38)	−3.80 (1.32)	−2.70 (1.29)	−3.22 (1.31)	−3.23 (1.31)
2 (Grandchildren)	3,386	−0.39 (1.39)	−1.43 (1.36)	−0.70 (1.39)	−1.13 (1.39)	−1.21 (1.38)
3	3,535	−0.42 (1.39)	−1.49 (1.42)	−0.29 (1.34)	−1.06 (1.27)	−1.05 (1.27)
4	3,574	−1.08 (1.29)	−2.53 (1.41)	−1.53 (1.25)	−2.10 (1.24)	−2.20 (1.24)
5	3,322	−0.17 (1.46)	−1.07 (1.44)	0.08 (1.40)	−0.15 (1.39)	−0.07 (1.40)
Index father's rank pre-1680			✓	✓	✓	✓
Index father's birth-decade FEs				✓	✓	✓
Index father's high nobility pre-1680					✓	✓
Index grandfather's rank pre-1680						✓

Notes: Descendants are ranked on manors within their generation. Confiscation lowered affected index fathers' rank by 14.6 percentiles on average. Standard errors are clustered by lineage.

Causal and mobility-implied wealth effects



Mobility-implied effects: initial wealth shock × intergenerational correlations. **Causal effects:** column (4) of the table

Conclusion

- **Economic history of the Great Reduction**
  - The Reduction affected nobles of all ranks
  - Those affected were united by having benefited from the policy of enfeoffment
  - Little evidence that the Reduction targeted Charles XI's political enemies
- **Long-run Inequality**
  - Wealth is highly correlated across generations
  - Evidence that these correlations partly reflect causal transmission of wealth
  - No evidence of compensating adjustments along other socioeconomic margins

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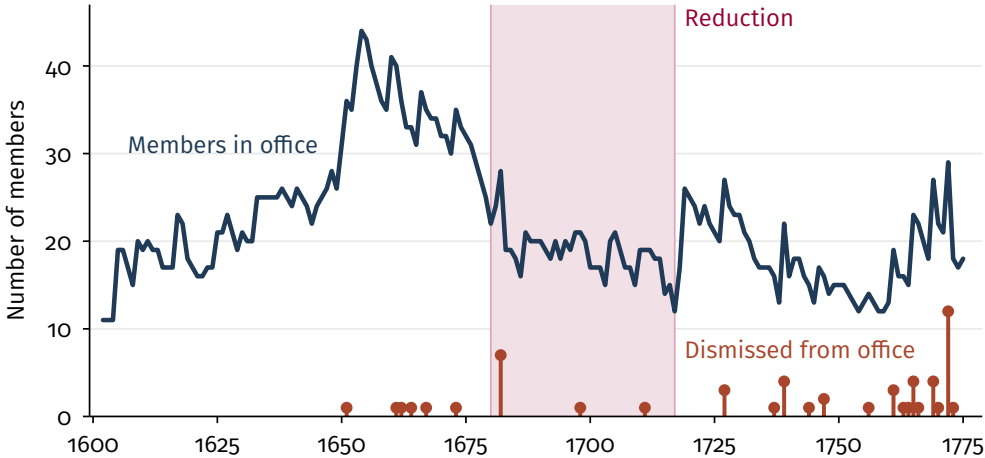
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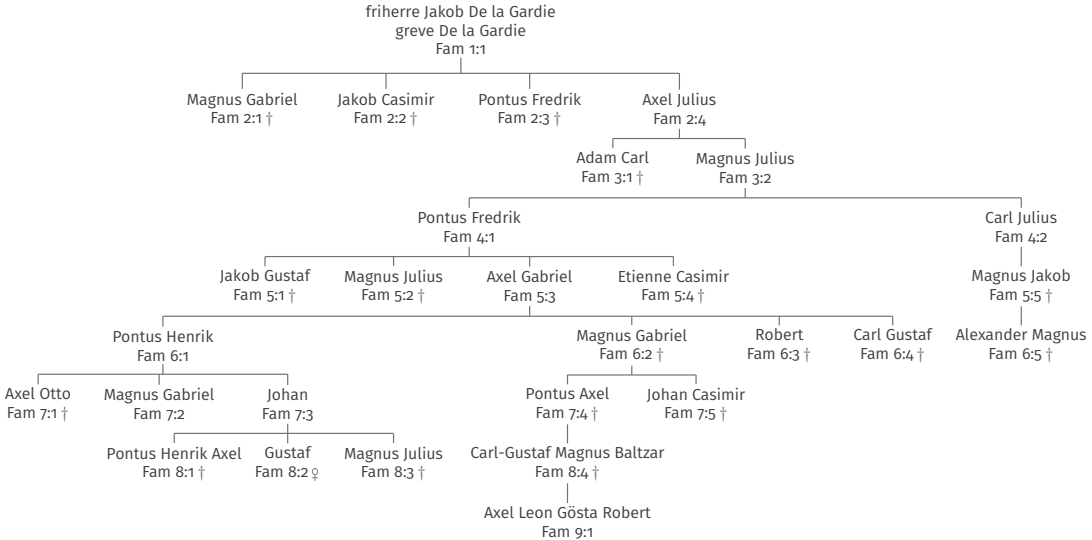
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The Privy Council



Data compiled based on Lewenhaupt (1962)

De la Gardie family tree



‹ Back

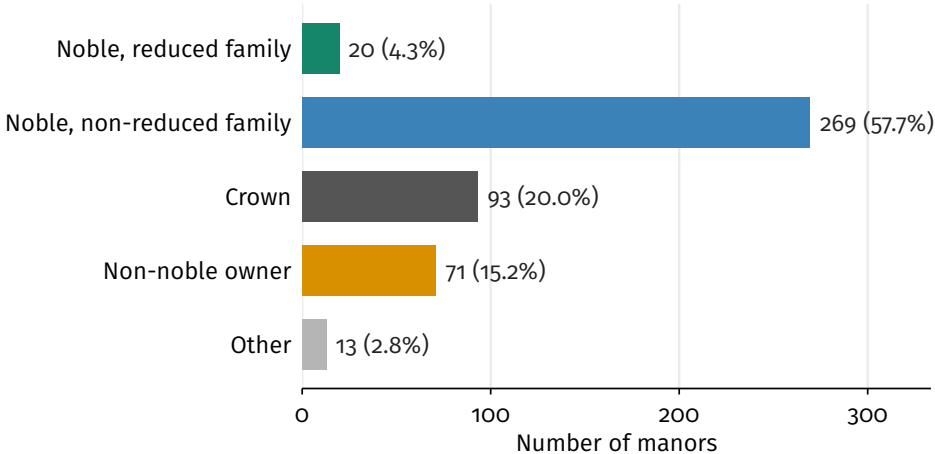
Source: Riddarhuset (2026)

Contribution

- **Effects of large wealth shocks** (Ager, Boustan, and Eriksson, 2021; Bleakley and Ferrie, 2016)
  - ↪ Consider political and social outcomes as well as role of social networks
- **Intergenerational mobility in the very long run** (Barone and Mocetti, 2021; Clark, 2014)
  - ↪ Estimates from **exact genealogical links** spanning three centuries
- **Persistence of elite through revolutions** (Alesina et al., 2020; Bukowski et al., 2022)
  - ↪ More specific measurements of individual responses
- **Economic history of the Great Reduction and the Swedish nobility** (Bengtsson et al., 2019; Heckscher, 1935–1936; Prytz, 2013; Svedelius, 1849–1851)
  - ↪ First estimates of the individual-level impact of the Great Reduction on the nobility

‹ Back

Ownership of confiscated noble manors c. 1750



Owner in the record closest to 1750, between 1730 and 1770

Historical Context

Confiscated Properties: Examples

The 1680—1682 Riksdag of Estates decreed confiscation of these properties:

- **Countships and baronies.** Properties granted from 1560 until the Great Reduction, when all were revoked without exception
- **Norrköping decree fiefs.** Properties granted after 1604 with inheritance restrictions; allowed families to retain rents up to 600 silver daler and decide which fiefs to transfer
- **Conquered territories.** Properties granted in territories conquered in the 17th century, including former Danish lands and Livonia (Lithuania and Latvia)

Läckö Otterstad, Källand, Västergötland Ladda ner som Excelfil

År början	År början anm	År slut	År slut anm	Status	Jordnatur	Ägarlarr	Typ	Titel tjänst	Titel familj	Namn	Efternamn	M1 titel tjänst	M1 titel familj	M1 namn	M1 efternamn	M2 titel tjänst	M2 titel familj	M2 namn	M2 efternamn	Herrgård mantal	Herrgård hektar	Herrgård hektar åker	Gods mantal	Gods hektar	Gods hektar åker	Taxering	Källa
1298				Herrgård		Ägare		Biskop		Brynolf	Algotsson																SlottochHerresätenVästergötland,Dalsland,Värmland1968
1300	Omkring			Herrgård		Ägare				Biskoparna i Skara																	SlottochHerresätenVästergötland,Dalsland,Värmland1968
1528				Herrgård		Ägare	Indraget			Svenska staten																	SlottochHerresätenVästergötland,Dalsland,Värmland1968
1543		1571		Herrgård	säteri	Ägare	Förlaning	riksråd	greve	Svante Stensson	Sture			Märta Eriksdotter	(Leijonhufvud)												SlottochHerresätenVästergötland,Dalsland,Värmland1968, EÄ
1569				Herrgård	säteri	Ägare	Förlaning		friherre	Hogenskild	Bielke af Åkerö																SlottochHerresätenVästergötland,Dalsland,Värmland1968, EÄ II s 227
1571		1591		Herrgård	säteri	Ägare	arv; dotter		grevinna	Anna	Sture	ståthållare	friherre	Hogenskild	Bielke af Åkerö												Almquist 1960 s 275
1591		1593		Herrgård	säteri	Ägare	Indraget			Svenska staten																	SlottochHerresätenVästergötland,Dalsland,Värmland1968
1593		1600		Herrgård	säteri	Ägare	återgick	ståthållare	friherre	Hogenskild	Bielke af Åkerö		grevinna	Anna	Sture												SlottochHerresätenVästergötland,Dalsland,Värmland1968, EÄ
1600		1615		Herrgård	säteri	Ägare	Förlaning		hertig	Johan	av Östergötland		Prinsessa	Maria Elisabet													SlottochHerresätenVästergötland,Dalsland,Värmland1968
1615		1652		Herrgård	säteri	Ägare	Förlaning	riksmarsk	greve	Jakob	De la Gardie		grevinna	Ebba	Brahe												SlottochHerresätenVästergötland,Dalsland,Värmland1968, EÄ II s 225
1652				Herrgård	säteri	Ägare	Arv; son	överste	greve	Jakob Casimir	De la Gardie		friherrinna	Ebba	Sparre												EÄ II s 227
1652				Herrgård	säteri	Ägare	Arv; son	överste	greve	Pontus Fredrik	De la Gardie		grevinna	Beata Elisabeth	von Königsmarck												EÄ II s 227
1652		1680		Herrgård	säteri	Ägare	Arv; son	riksdrots	greve	Magnus Gabriel	De la Gardie		prinsessa	Maria Eufrosyne													SlottochHerresätenVästergötland,Dalsland,Värmland1968, EÄ II s 226
1680		1752		Herrgård	krono;kungsgård	Ägare	Indraget			Svenska staten																	SlottochHerresätenVästergötland,Dalsland,Värmland1968
1720				Herrgård	krono;kungsgård	Arrendator		riksråd	greve	Carl Gustaf	Dücker		grevinna	Hedvig Vilhelmina	Oxenstierna af Korsholm och Vasa												SvenskaGodsOchGårdar, SkaraborgsLän, 1941, EA II s 375
1730	Omkring			Herrgård	krono;kungsgård	Arrendator		riksråd	greve	Claes	Ekeblad		grevinna	Eva	De la Gardie												SvenskaGodsOchGårdar, SkaraborgsLän, 1941, EÄ II s 228, 507
1752		1770		Herrgård	krono;kungsgård	Arrendator		kanslipresident	greve	Carl Gustaf	Tessin		grevinna	Ulrika Lovisa	Sparre af Sundby												SvenskaGodsOchGårdar, SkaraborgsLän, 1941,Värmland1968, EÄ VIII s 241
1770	Omkring	1805		Herrgård	krono;kungsgård	Arrendator		riksråd	greve	Gustaf Adolf	Hjärne			Anna Maria	Ehrensvärd												SvenskaGodsOchGårdar, SkaraborgsLän, 1941, EA III s 641
1810		1815		Herrgård	krono;kungsgård	Ägare	Förlaning	exellens	greve	Carl Johan	Adlercreutz			Margareta Beata	von Engeström												SlottochHerresätenVästergötland,Dalsland,Värmland1968, EÄ II s 580
1815		1845		Herrgård	krono;kungsgård	Ägare	Förlaning; bror	överste		Gustaf Magnus	Adlercreutz			Elisabet Charlotta	von Arbin												SlottochHerresätenVästergötland,Dalsland,Värmland1968, EÄ
1845		1864		Herrgård	krono;kungsgård	Ägare	Förlaning; svärson	kapten	greve	Carl	Rudenschöld			Margareta Charlotta Christina Sofia	Adlercreutz												SvenskaGodsOchGårdar, SkaraborgsLän, 1941, EÄ VI s 601
1864		1914		Herrgård	krono;kungsgård	Arrendator	arv; son	överste	greve	Axel	Rudenschöld			Sara Eufrosyne Gunilla	Wennerberg												SvenskaGodsOchGårdar, SkaraborgsLän, 1941, EÄ VI s 601
1883	omkring			Herrgård	krono;kungsgård															5.00			5.00			135000	Rosenberg 1882-1883
1914		1923		Herrgård	krono;kungsgård	Arrendator				Friberg/Billing																	https://sv.wikipedia.org/wiki/L%C3%A4ckö%C3%B6_slott
1923		1937		Herrgård	krono;kungsgård	Arrendator				Adolf	Gustafsson																https://sv.wikipedia.org/wiki/L%C3%A4ckö%C3%B6_slott
1930	Omkring			Herrgård	krono;kungsgård	Ägare				Svenska staten													4.17	1000.00	250.00	350000	Åkerhielm 1930
1937		1961		Herrgård	krono;kungsgård	Arrendator				Ragnar	Jansson																https://sv.wikipedia.org/wiki/L%C3%A4ckö%C3%B6_slott
1938				Herrgård	krono;kungsgård	Arrendator				Erik Ragnar	Jansson																SvenskaGodsOchGårdar, SkaraborgsLän, 1941
1938				Herrgård	krono;kungsgård	Arrendator				Karl Gustaf	Jansson																SvenskaGodsOchGårdar, SkaraborgsLän, 1941
1942				Herrgård	krono;kungsgård	Ägare				Svenska staten														219.00	130.00	112500	SvenskaGodsOchGårdar, SkaraborgsLän, 1941
1961		1968		Herrgård	krono;kungsgård	Arrendator				Gunnar	Nilsson																https://sv.wikipedia.org/wiki/L%C3%A4ckö%C3%B6_slott
1968		2013		Herrgård	krono;kungsgård	Arrendator				Christer	Svederberg																https://sv.wikipedia.org/wiki/L%C3%A4ckö%C3%B6_slott
2013				Herrgård	krono;kungsgård	Arrendator	arv; son			Carl-Fredrik	Svederberg																https://sv.wikipedia.org/wiki/L%C3%A4ckö%C3%B6_slott

Types of Manors Confiscated

Category	Revenue	Share
Conquered territories	1,017,378	0.651
Sweden and Finland	272,689	0.174
Sweden	84,515	0.054
Kexholm County, Ingria	188,174	0.120
Baltic provinces	544,512	0.348
Estonia	86,428	0.055
Livonia	458,084	0.293
Other provinces	200,176	0.128
Bremen–Verden	200,176	0.128
Allodial properties	170,620	0.109
Countships and baronies	128,060	0.082
Former military fiefs	96,508	0.062
Former royal mansions	82,409	0.053
Fiefs granted under the Norrköping decree of 1604	12,231	0.008
Other	55,592	0.036

Historical Context

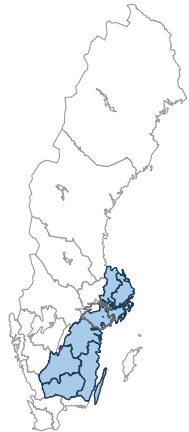
Great Reduction

The Reduction specifically targeted the manors that had been alienated (i.e., granted):

> *But with the allodial donations, the same situation arose as with the Norrköping resolution estates, namely that some had been transferred through purchase from man to man. […] The Reduction commission did not know where to find the sellers, nor whether they still owned the estates, how large they were, or where they were located.*
>
> — *Svedelius (1849–1851), translated from Swedish*

Almquist's regions

- Covers 41% of taxable land in present-day Sweden in 1700
- Covers 52% of the value of manorial holdings confiscated in Sweden in the Great Reduction



Regions covered by Almquist (1931–1976)

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